

Early Jets

With the advent of the jet engine, entirely new types of combat aircraft began to appear. Radically different in appearance, and with top speeds significantly faster than their piston-powered predecessors, these new fighters and bombers would change the course of aerial combat forever.



▷ Gloster Whittle E.28/39 1941

Origin UK

Engine 868 lb (394 kg) thrust Power Jets W.1 turbojet

Top speed 338 mph (544 km/h)

Although only two of these little jets were built, the E.28/39 has enormous historic significance because it was Britain's first jet aircraft. Intended purely as an engine testbed, it was by all accounts a pleasant aircraft to fly, with reasonable performance.



△ Gloster Meteor prototype DG202G 1943

Origin UK

Engine 2 x 3,500 lb (1,588 kg) thrust Rolls-Royce Derwent turbojets

Top speed 415 mph (668 km/h)

This was the only Allied jet to see combat in WWII. The Meteor had a long military career—it remained in production until the mid-1950s—and set several speed records. The type was sold to many foreign air forces, and even today two Meteors are used as testbeds for ejection-seat manufacturer Martin-Baker.



△ Messerschmitt Me262 Schwalbe 1942

Origin Germany

Engine 2 x 1,980 lb (898 kg) thrust Junkers Jumo 004 B-1 turbojets

Top speed 559 mph (900 km/h)

This very advanced aircraft was the world's first operational jet fighter. Although much faster than any piston machine, it was hampered by the lack of dive brakes, and also the short life and inherent unreliability of its Jumo turbojets.



△ de Havilland DH100 Vampire FB 6 1943

Origin UK

Engine 3,350 lb (1,520 kg) thrust de Havilland Goblin 3 turbojet

Top speed 548 mph (882 km/h)

Designed and built by famed British aircraft manufacturer de Havilland, the Vampire was the RAF's second jet fighter, and the company's first jet. Two unusual facets of the aircraft are that a lot of wood (plywood and balsa) was used in its construction, and that both engine and airframe were built by the same company.



△ Bell P-59A Airacomet 1944

Origin USA

Engine 2 x 2,000 lb (907 kg) thrust General Electric J31-GE-3 turbojets

Top speed 413 mph (665 km/h)

The Airacomet was America's first jet aircraft. It was deemed a most unsatisfactory machine by all that flew it as it was not only slower than most contemporary piston fighters but also had poor handling and stability. It is notable for being the first jet to have two engines integrated into the fuselage.



▷ Heinkel He162 1944

Origin Germany

Engine 1,760 lb (798 kg) thrust BMW 003 turbojet

Top speed 562 mph (905 km/h)

Known as the "Volksjäger" (People's Fighter) the He162 was intended to be a cheap, simple aircraft that could be flown by relatively inexperienced pilots. Unfortunately, because it was rushed into production it had many design flaws, and the prototype crashed on only its second flight.